development partnerships or opening of embassies. Indian citizens of every category are more assured that their concerns are addressed and interests advanced.

The benefits at home of a more proactive approach abroad are equally visible. On the global stage, India's greater relevance is being demonstrated in a variety of ways. Some of it was evident in the conversations and agenda, especially on terrorism, black money, etc. It was also visible, in outcomes and initiatives, notably in Paris and Glasgow on climate change. Our willingness to step forward in disaster-relief situations and to meet the Covid challenge has also been appreciated by the international community. Our national persona, be it on democracy, innovation, yoga, millets or Ayurveda, has gained recognition. We have, in the last few years, steadily built up the image of a first responder, pharmacy of the world, a reservoir of talent, climate action leader, development partner and cultural powerhouse.

When 10 ASEAN or five Central Asian leaders (virtually) attend our Republic Day, 27 European ones engage us together in a meeting or 41 African leaders come to India for a summit, clearly something has changed for the better. This is the India that took on the presidency of the G20 at a time when the world was, and continues to be, sharply polarized. It used this occasion to not only validate an approach of engaging multiple partners but also speaking up for the Global South.

A stronger and more capable India, one truer to its roots and culture, is a key factor in the larger rebalancing that characterizes our contemporary world. At a time when there are many more power centres, our place in a multipolar order is clearly more assured. In an era that is more globalized, our talents, capabilities and contribution have a growing value for the rest of the world. As we celebrate 75 years of independence, there is good cause for Bharat to be confident about its prospects. But to be so, it is equally important to be fully aware of the opportunities and challenges that the world currently presents. And surely, that will happen once we appreciate that foreign policy really matters to us.